



NCERT QUESTIONS WITH SOLUTIONS

1. Describe the circumstances leading to the outbreak of revolutionary protest in France.

Ans. Louis XVI of the Bourbon family of kings ascended the throne of France in 1774. Upon his accession he found that his treasury was empty. Long wars with Britain, the cost of maintaining an extravagant court at the immense palace of Versailles, cost of maintaining a regular army, court, running government offices, etc., had depleted the treasury. Louis XVI was forced to increase taxes. But this measure would not have sufficed as taxes were paid only by the third estate in the society.

The French society during this time was divided as :

- (a) Peasants made up about 90% of the population. However, very few owned land. About 60% of the land was owned by nobles, the church and the richer members of the third estate. The members of the first two estates enjoyed privileges and paid no taxes. The peasants had to pay the taxes, render services, serve in the army and work in the lord's house and fields. The Third Estate had to pay taxes such as tithes to the church, taille, a direct tax and many other indirect taxes.
- (b) The population of France also increased from 23 million in 1715 to 28 million in 1789. Food grains were now in great demand. Price of bread shot up. The supply could not match with the need and hence the subsistence crisis.

- (c) The 18th century witnessed the emergence of social groups, termed the middle class. All these people were educated and believed that no group in society should be given privileges by birth. Such ideas which spoke of freedom and equal laws and opportunities for all were put forward by philosophers such as Voltaire and Rousseau.

- (d) The ideas of these philosophers were discussed intensively in salons and coffee houses and spread among people through books and newspapers and even through loud reading for people who could not read or write. The news about imposing further taxes generated anger and protest against the system of privileges.

- (e) The king had to increase the taxes for various reasons. He had to call a meeting of the Estates General which then would pass the proposals for new taxes. The assembly of the Estates General was called on 5th May 1789. Voting in the Estates General had been conducted according to the principle that each estate had one vote. Members of the third estate demanded that voting now be conducted by the assembly as a whole, where each member would have one vote. This was according to the democratic principles put forward by philosophers. The king rejected this proposal and the members of the third estate walked out of the Assembly.



(f) On 20th June, the members of the third estate assembled in the hall of an indoor tennis court in the grounds of Versailles. They declared themselves as a National Assembly.

At this time, France went through a severe winter and the price of bread increased. Women were angry and annoyed. They stormed into shops for bread. At the same time, the king ordered troops to move into Paris. On 14 July the agitated crowd stormed the Bastille. This is taken as the beginning of the French Revolution and is known as the storming of the Bastille.

2. Which groups of French society benefitted from the revolution? Which groups were forced to relinquish power? Which sections of society would have been disappointed with the outcome of the revolution?

Ans. The wealthy class of the third estate which came to be known as the new middle class of France benefited the most from the revolution. This group comprised of big businessmen, petty officers, lawyers, teachers, doctors and traders. Previously, these people had to pay state taxes and they did not enjoy equal status. But after the revolution they began to be treated equally with the upper sections of the society.

With the abolition of feudal system of obligation and taxes, the clergy and the nobility came on the same level with the middle class. They were forced to give up their privileges. Their executive powers were also taken away from them. The

poorer sections of the society, i.e. small peasants, landless labourers, servants, daily wage earners would have been disappointed with the outcome of the revolution. Women also would have been highly discontented.

3. Describe the legacy of the French Revolution for the people of the world during the nineteenth and twentieth centuries.

Ans. The French Revolution not only affected France and changed its entire social and political system; it also had a lasting effect on the people of Europe in the 19th century. It inspired the Germans, Italians, and Austrians to overthrow their oppressive regimes. It led to a decade of political changes and Europe saw many revolutions inspired by the French Revolution.

The watchwords of the French Revolution such as liberty, equality and fraternity reflected the coming of a new democratic and social order in Europe and the world. The French Revolution inspired the struggling nations of Asia and Africa who were groaning under the oppression of colonialism. Many a nation aspiring for liberty sought inspiration from its ideas of liberty, equality and fraternity.

India's struggle for independence was inspired by the ideas of the great French philosophers like Voltaire and Rousseau and fired by the ideas expressed in the Rights of Man (1789). The French Revolution put into practice the idea that sovereignty comes from the people, from below and not from above.



NCERT Basics : Class 9

4. Draw up a list of democratic rights we enjoy today whose origins could be traced to the French Revolution.

Ans. Right to equality including equality before the law, the prohibition of discrimination, and equality of opportunity in matters of employment.

- Right to freedom of speech and expression including the right to practice any profession or occupation.
- Right against exploitation.
- Right to life.
- Right to vote.

5. Would you agree with the view that the message of universal rights was beset with contradictions? Explain.

Ans. The message of universal rights was beset with contradictions. The universal rights lay emphasis on the inalienable rights of man which mention property as one right which no government can ensure. Property will be owned by some and not by all. Even the ownership cannot be an equal division for all.

The Declaration also says that all citizens have the right to participate in the formation of laws, personally or through

their representatives. All citizens are equal before it. But for this a country must have free and fair elections which does not happen everywhere. The universal rights also say that every citizen may speak, write and print freely. For this there must be freedom of press which in many governments is restricted.

6. How would you explain the rise of Napoleon?

Ans. The fall of the Jacobin government allowed the wealthier middle classes to seize power. A new constitution was introduced which denied the vote to non-propertied sections of society. It provided for two elected legislative councils. These then appointed a Directory, an executive made up of five members. This was meant as a safeguard against the concentration of power in a one-man executive as under the Jacobins. However, the Directors often clashed with the legislative councils, who then sought to dismiss them. The political instability of the Directory paved the way for the rise of a military dictator, Napoleon Bonaparte.

**EXERCISE-01****Multiple choice questions**

1. The word livres stands for **STF026**
(1) Unit of currency in France
(2) Tax levied by the Church
(3) Tax to be paid directly to the state
(4) None of these
2. The Third Estate comprised of **STF027**
(1) Poor servants and small peasants, landless labourers
(2) Peasants and artisans
(3) Big businessmen, merchants, lawyers etc.
(4) All the above
3. How does a 'Subsistence Crisis' happen?
(1) Bad harvest leads to scarcity of grains
(2) Food prices rise and the poorest cannot buy bread
(3) Leads to weaker bodies, diseases, deaths and even food riots
(4) All the above **STF028**
4. Which of these books was written by John Locke? **STF029**
(1) The Spirit of the Laws
(2) Two Treatises of Government
(3) The Social Contract
(4) All the above
5. In the meeting of the Estates General, the members of the Third Estate demanded that **STF030**
(1) All the three Estates should have one vote altogether
(2) Each member should have one vote
(3) Each Estate should have one vote
(4) None of the above
6. What did Louis XVI do, seeing the power of his revolting subjects? **STF031**
(1) He accorded recognition to the National Assembly
(2) Accepted checks on his powers
(3) Ordered his army to crush the revolt
(4) Both (1) and (2)
7. According to the new constitution of 1791, the National Assembly was to be
(1) Elected directly **STF032**
(2) Appointed by the king
(3) Elected indirectly
(4) A hereditary body
8. Which of these rights were established as 'natural and inalienable' rights by the constitution of 1791? **STF033**
(1) Right to life
(2) Freedom of speech and opinion
(3) Equality before the law
(4) All the above
9. In the war against Prussia and Austria, the army sang which patriotic song?
(1) 'Liberty', written by an unknown woman poet **STF034**
(2) 'Marseillaise' written by the poet Roget de L'Isle
(3) 'Viva France' written by a French peasant
(4) None of the above
10. From which Palace, king was arrested before being executed? **STF035**
(1) Palace of Versailles
(2) Palace of Paris
(3) Palace of Tuileries
(4) Marseilles



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11. Many Jacobins came to be known as the 'sans-culottes'. What does it mean? **STF036**
(1) People without knee breeches
(2) People with black shirts
(3) People with black trousers
(4) People without shirts
12. Why is the period from 1793 to 1794 referred to as the 'Reign of Terror'? **STF037**
(1) Louis XVI's successor became a tyrant
(2) Robespierre followed a policy of severe control and punishment
(3) Jacobins opted for loot and plunder
(4) None of the above
13. Who seized power after the fall of the Jacobin government? **STF038**
(1) Common people
(2) Descendants of Louis XVI
(3) Wealthy middle class
(4) Robespierre's son
14. Women of which estate had to work for a living - **STF039**
(1) First estate
(2) Second estate
(3) Third estate
(4) All of the above
15. Which government did introduce laws that helped improve the lives of women?
(1) Louis XVI's Government **STF040**
(2) Revolutionary Government
(3) Directory
(4) Napoleon
16. Who among the following reintroduced slavery in France after it was abolished by Jacobin regime? **STF041**
(1) Louis XVI
(2) Robespierre
(3) Napoleon
(4) Marat
17. Who wrote an influential pamphlet, what is the third Estate? **STF042**
(1) Mirabeau
(2) Jean-Paul Marat
(3) Abbe Sieyes
(4) Olympe de Gouges
18. In which of the following battles was Napoleon finally defeated? **STF043**
(1) Russia
(2) Waterloo
(3) Versailles
(4) Paris
19. Which Revolution gave the ideas of Liberty, Freedom and Equality to the world? **STF044**
(1) The American Revolution
(2) The French Revolution
(3) The Russian Revolution
(4) None of these
20. Name the leader who got inspired by new ideas that were spreading through Europe, during the French Revolution.
(1) Raja Rammohan Roy **STF045**
(2) Tipu Sultan
(3) Both (1) & (2)
(4) Jyotiba Phule

**True or false**

1. Under Louis XV, France helped the thirteen American colonies to gain their independence from the common enemy, Britain. **STF046**
2. The population of France rose from about 23 million in 1715 to 28 million in 1789. **STF047**
3. In his, 'Two Treatises of Government', Montesquieu sought to refute the doctrine of the divine and absolute right of the monarch. **STF048**
4. Voting in the Estates General in the past had been conducted according to the principle that each Estate had one vote. **STF049**
5. The Directory vested the power to make laws in the National Assembly, which was indirectly elected. **STF050**

Fill in the blanks

1. The term _____ is usually used to describe the society and institutions of France before 1789. **STF051**
2. The gap between the poor and the rich widened. Things became worse whenever drought or hail reduced the harvest. This led to a _____ crisis. **STF052**
3. The ideas of _____ were discussed intensively in salons and coffee-houses and spread among people through books and newspaper. **STF053**
4. _____ was born in a noble family but was convinced of the need to do away with a society of feudal privilege. **STF054**
5. _____ resembled the symbol of royal power. **STF055**

Match the columns**STF056**

Column I		Column II	
(A)	1774	(i)	A constitution is framed to limit the powers of the King and to guarantee basic rights to all human beings.
(B)	1789	(ii)	Napoleon defeated at Waterloo
(C)	1791	(iii)	Convocation of Estates General, Third Estate forms National Assembly, the Bastille is stormed, peasants revolt in the countryside
(D)	1792-93	(iv)	Napoleon becomes emperor of France, annexes large parts of Europe
(E)	1804	(v)	Louis XVI becomes king of France, faces empty treasure and growing discontent within society of the Old Regime.
(F)	1815	(vi)	France becomes a republic, the king is beheaded. Overthrow of the Jacobin republic, a Directory rules France.



ANSWER KEY

Multiple choice questions

Question	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12	13	14	15
Answer	1	4	4	2	2	4	3	4	2	3	1	2	3	3	2
Question	16	17	18	19	20										
Answer	3	3	2	2	3										

True or false

1. False
2. True
3. False
4. True
5. False

Fill in the blanks

1. Old Regime
2. Subsistence
3. Philosophers
4. Mirabeau
5. Sceptre

Match the column

1. (A) → (v) ; (B) → (iii) ; (C) → (i) ; (D) → (vi) ; (E) → (iv) ; (F) → (ii)

**EXERCISE-02****Short Answer Type Questions**

1. What was the subsistence crisis? Why did it occur in France during the Old Regime? **STF057**
2. What was the system of voting in the Estates General? What change did the Third Estate want in this system? **STF058**
3. Describe the incidents that led to the storming of the Bastille. **STF059**
4. Describe how the new political system of constitutional monarchy worked in France. **STF060**
5. What were 'natural and inalienable rights'? **STF061**
6. What was the importance of the Declaration of the Rights of Man? **STF062**
7. Who were the Sans-Culottes? **STF063**
8. Discuss the role of women in the French Revolution. **STF064**
9. Why did slavery begin and when was it abolished in French colonies? **STF065**
10. What are the three important ideas of the French Revolution? **STF066**

Long Answer Type Questions

11. Discuss the political, economic, and social causes of the French Revolution. **STF067**
12. 'The French philosophers of the 18th century greatly influenced the people and it led to the French Revolution.' Comment on this statement. **STF068**
13. What did the following symbols convey in the Declaration of Rights? **STF069**
 - (1) The broken chain
 - (2) The bundle of rods or fasces
 - (3) The eye within a triangle radiating light
 - (4) Sceptre
 - (5) Snake biting its tail to form a ring
 - (6) Red Phrygian cap
 - (7) Blue-White-Red
 - (8) The winged woman
 - (9) The Law Tablet
14. Who were the Jacobins? What was their contribution to the French Revolution? **STF070**
15. Describe the Reign of Terror and role played by Robespierre in it. **STF071**

